

NIP AND TUCK:
Nisha Kothari (right)



SHRIYA PATIL

SMALL TOWN STARLETS

Mumbai | MAHARASHTRA



Stars in her eyes

Raised in a West Bengal village, Nisha Kothari is emblematic of a new brand of wannabe wowies ready to storm Bollywood with nothing more than their ambition

■ By Swati Mathur

Two kinds of people survive in Bollywood. Those who become brash and sport an I-don't-care attitude, or, those who remain like Nisha Kothari, 23, wide-eyed at the continuing wonder of her rising stardom. So how did Priyanka Kothari, 23, born into a conservative God-fearing Jain family from the town of Chhapar in north-western Rajasthan, become a panty-flashing Britney clone—the Nisha Kothari of Ram Gopal Varma's item songs? When did the girl, born and brought up in Majdia village in West Bengal's Nadia district, learn to tempt and tease on screen?

"I have always loved the idea of dancing around the trees. Joining the film industry had always

been my dream," she says. But it took some convincing. Her father, a Delhi-based businessman, was angry at her decision but she managed to buy some time, promising to return home if things didn't work out. Two months stretched further and she never went back. Her debut in 2003—a Tamil film *Jay Jay* opposite Madhavan—didn't lead to a flood of offers but she didn't waver. A visit to Varma's office—where she says, "I just sat in front of Ramuji and didn't speak a word. At the end of the meeting, he asked the coordinator whether I could speak at all."—didn't pan out as she had planned, but a second visit landed her the part of Sandhya, the film actor in *Sarkar*.

"For me films are not about money. They are my passion. The experience of being able to hobnob with the who's who of the film industry, to brush shoulders with the Hrithik Roshans and Amitabh Bachchans is incredibly exciting," she says.

Despite the absence of star 'uncles and aunties',

Kothari has been able to shed the girl-next-door image and become

Bollywood's item

girl. Does she mind being called that? "I'm just doing my work. I may have given some shots I'd like to change in retrospect, or worn costumes I wouldn't want to wear again, but none of it has been forced upon me," she says nonchalantly.

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